


topsy-turvy and undermined the whole globalisation movement. Covid disrupted supply chains across the globe and served as a stark reminder of how interdependent the world had become, specially regarding China, which had become the world's factory. Businesses worldwide started to explore 'China Plus 1'. It represented an excellent opportunity for India. And we have been doing well on this front. One statistic illustrates this really well. Since its Independence in 1947, India has received roughly $950 billion in FDI. Believe it or not, of this, 56 per cent, or $532 billion, has come in the last 90 months.

This is India's moment.

Second is the Ukraine War, which started a little more than a year ago. Besides the terrible human tragedy, it has disrupted world trade, created food shortages, raised energy prices and further splintered the world, forcing nations to pick sides. India's difficult but so far deft handling of its relations with Russia has seen it emerge as a bridge and a key negotiator between what is called the Global North and the Global South. We have seen multiple pieces of evidence of this in the past year and will see more in this year of India's G20 presidency.

This, again, is India's moment.

The disillusionment of most of the developed world with China is also working to our advantage. The rise of China is seen as a threat by most of the world, while the rise of India is seen as benign and a global good. India is a democracy and the world respects us for this. No democracy is perfect. Ours is noisy, chaotic and messy. Even mature democracies like the USA and UK have serious issues. Our democracy is our biggest asset. We must protect it. Without it, we will not survive as a nation.

Let me here say a word about the media. We are the favourite whipping boy for many. There is talk of *godi* media and *thodo* media. But the point is that you have a plethora of choices. You watch or read whatever appeals to you. There are 400 24*7 news channels, approximately 150,000 newspapers, and countless websites. Do you think anyone can control all this? And I am not even counting social media, which is another animal. Free media is essential for our democracy. Just think—would the country be better-off without it?

Despite many daunting challenges, I am optimistic about India. For all its flaws, India has a momentum of its own. And it is bigger than any one leader. I am optimistic because India's attitude has changed from '*chalta hai*' to 'can do' to now 'doing or done'. I believe India now has the capability, capacity, credibility, creativity and leadership to meet all our challenges. That's what sets this 'India's Moment' apart from such moments in the past. ■

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